

PART 4 OF 5. WRITE THE MESSAGE AND DECIDE HOW REPLIES ARE HANDLED.

Send it where people already are

Your preview should now identify the right items and recipients. Before you enable delivery, show a sample message to the people in your pilot. Agree on where they'll receive it, how often it can repeat, and what happens to a reply.

Start with direct messages for these individual follow-ups. A private message avoids putting a person's overdue item in front of a group, but it still needs their agreement and your company's approval. It may also be retained under company policy.

1 Confirm the recipient and the destination

Match the tracker owner's account to the messaging account using an approved directory or mapping. Don't choose an account because its display name looks right. Hold shared accounts, missing owners, and ambiguous matches for review.

Use one work item per message. If you list several items and someone replies "done," you won't know which item they mean without asking.

EXAMPLE

Pilot invitation: "I'm testing a reminder for work items that meet the rules we reviewed. Are you willing to try it? Each message will link to one item. During the first test, I'll review replies manually and won't copy anything back automatically. Tell me if the owner, date, or timing is wrong."

Confirm the platform's delivery permissions with whoever manages the integration. Access to read the tracker doesn't grant permission to message people or write their replies back.

WHY THIS MATTERS: the fastest way to make people resent a reminder is to post it where their team can read it. A direct message to a confirmed account is most of what makes this acceptable to the person receiving it.

2 Say what the tracker shows and ask one clear question

Include the item ID, a link the recipient can open, the recorded facts, and a question they can answer. Make it clear that this is an automated reminder and name the person to contact if something is wrong.

The examples below use fictional items. Add the actual item link when you adapt them.

EXAMPLE

Overdue: "Hey Alex, DEMO-101 is listed as In progress with a September 21 due date. Does the tracker need an update? [Item link] Automated reminder. For corrections or to pause reminders, contact [pilot owner]."

EXAMPLE

Due soon, unchanged: "Hey Alex, DEMO-103 is due September 29 and has stayed In progress since September 8. Is the recorded due date still right? [Item link] Automated reminder. For corrections or to pause reminders, contact [pilot owner]."

If you're still reviewing replies manually, say so. Don't promise automatic updates before you've built and tested that path. Avoid "no progress" or "ignored reminders" when all you know is the recorded state or the absence of a matched reply.

WHY THIS MATTERS: someone should be able to read this on their phone and answer it in eight words. Anything longer gets saved for later, and later doesn't come.

3 Match the reply before writing anything back

Start by reading replies yourself. Before automating the transfer, verify how your chosen platform links a reply to its original message. A plain direct message may not include the reference you need.

Save the platform, conversation or thread reference, original message ID, source tracker, item ID, intended recipient ID, and send time. A reply can be considered for transfer only when its reference matches that record and its sender is authorized to update the item.

EXAMPLE

The sender replies "Waiting on the test environment" to the message for DEMO-101. The system finds that original message and confirms the sender. It proposes a comment on DEMO-101. The same words sent as an unrelated message stay in the review list.

If your integration can't establish that match, keep the transfer manual. Don't use the newest reminder, a similar title, or a display name to guess. The reviewer can ask which item the person meant and open that record themselves.

Test a correctly linked reply, an unrelated message, a reply from the wrong account, and a duplicate delivery of the same reply event. Only the authorized, matched reply should produce a proposed write, and a duplicate event shouldn't create another comment.

WHY THIS MATTERS: a guessed match puts one person's sentence on another person's work item. After that happens the tracker is less reliable than it was before you built anything.

4 Preserve the person's words and the record of the transfer

Tell participants where replies will appear and who can read them. A work item may have a wider audience than a direct message. During the pilot, review each proposed comment before copying it.

Keep the reply's wording and attribute it to the sender with the timestamp and time zone. Include a source-message link when the platform supports it and the intended readers have access.

EXAMPLE

Proposed tracker comment: "Reported by Alex Example on September 22, 2026 at 9:18 AM America/Los_Angeles. Relayed from the matched pilot message by the automation after review. Owner's words: Waiting on the test environment."

Don't translate "should be fine" into "on track," change a due date from an ambiguous sentence, or mark work complete because someone replied "done." Those changes need their own agreed meaning and confirmation. Keep automatic state and date updates off for this pilot.

Track the reply event ID and the resulting tracker comment ID so repeated events don't create repeated comments. If a write times out and you don't know whether it succeeded, pause that item and inspect the tracker before retrying. Route edited replies, attachments, and corrections for review until you've defined and tested their handling.

WHY THIS MATTERS: the moment somebody finds an update with their name on it that they didn't write in those words, they stop trusting the tool and they tell the rest of the team.

5 Choose frequency separately from message size

One item per message doesn't mean one message per person per day. Set the frequency with the team and make any waiting messages visible to the pilot owner.

Fill out this delivery sheet:

- ☐ Participants and item scope:
- ☐ Send window, time zone, and days to avoid:
- ☐ Maximum messages per run:
- ☐ Maximum messages per person in that window:

- ☐ Minimum interval before reminding about the same item again:
- ☐ Where to review messages held by either limit:
- ☐ Who can pause reminders, and how:

For the initial pilot, hold a batch that exceeds either limit and review it before sending. If you later choose to queue individual items, define their order and show which ones are waiting. Recheck owners, dates, and completed states before releasing an old queued message.

EXAMPLE

One person has four qualifying items, but the proposed batch exceeds the limit you agreed on. The preview lists all four as held. You review the items and adjust the batch with the participant before enabling that run.

WHY THIS MATTERS: one item per message keeps replies unambiguous, but it also multiplies the message count. The per-person limit is what stops a well-behaved tool from arriving as eleven notifications on a Monday morning.

Before the first send, confirm the recipient mapping, final message text, delivery limits, and reply behavior with the pilot participants.

Part 5 checks whether stop controls, duplicate protection, and failure notifications work when a run goes wrong.